

EG Italy: Meloni faces tight re-election odds

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Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni is the slight favorite to secure a majority (a 60% probability) in a likely spring election, with a 30% probability of a center-left coalition, and an outside chance of a hung parliament (10%).

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Meloni's chances of winning a second term hinge on changing the electoral system and on integrating the new far-right National Future (FN) into her coalition; while both are likely, Meloni's overall odds are not very high given her slim lead, and mixed record on the economy and foreign policy.

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The policy outlook will deteriorate marginally regardless of the outcome, resulting in more ambivalent support for Ukraine, even less scope for economic reforms, and a higher risk of fiscal slippage.

Meloni is likely to win a second term (60% probability). The emergence of a big-tent opposition alliance, rise of a rival far-right party, National Future (FN), and corresponding decline in support for the ruling coalition have made the election more competitive. In response, the government is working to change the electoral system to tip the scale in its favor. Eurasia Group puts a center-left coalition at 30% probability, and a hung parliament at 10%. The elections are scheduled to be held by August 2027, but the vote is more likely to be brought forward to spring; late April is a more likely option than May or June.

Coalition-building and electoral reform matter as much as voting intentions. With the electoral system, coalitions, and party alignment in flux, the outcome is uncertain. On balance, the right-wing coalition is likely to retain a majority, but on two conditions: that the planned changes to the electoral system go ahead, and that FN is co-opted into the alliance. Both are likely (an 85% and 70% probability, respectively). However, Meloni's slim polling lead and questions over voter retention mean the outcome is in the balance.

Changing the electoral system will give Meloni an advantage. Eurasia Group sees an 85% probability that the proposed changes will be enacted. This would replace the current hybrid system with proportional representation. However, a sizeable seat premium would guarantee the most-voted coalition a stable majority of 55% of the seats in both houses (provided it receives at least 42% of the

vote). Like the old system, it forces parties to form electoral coalitions but also requires them to pick a candidate beforehand.

Despite lingering disagreement among coalition partners, parliament is likely to enact the changes by October. The bill may then be referred to the constitutional court, which could amend some provisions but is unlikely to strike down its key elements.

Bringing National Future into the fold will be key for Meloni. Now polling at over 7%, the party has overtaken Brothers' two junior coalition partners—Lega and Forza Italia—mainly to Lega's and (less so) Brothers' detriment. As a result, collectively, the ruling coalition is now trailing the opposition. This gives Meloni and her allies strong incentives to bring FN into the fold ahead of the vote, however reluctantly. While FN has been very critical of the government, it hinted at its willingness to join (a 70% probability).

The election will be close: neither coalition is cohesive, and voter retention is key. After factoring in FN, the right has a steady 4% lead on paper. However, FN's radical profile and divisive leader, retired Italian Army general Roberto Vannacci, will alienate some moderate voters and could boost turnout on the left. This could be partly offset by FN's ability to attract disaffected voters who might otherwise abstain. Whether support for the coalition holds up once FN formally joins is a key signpost.

While an incumbent has not won re-election since 1948, Meloni is the most popular politician, with 40% approval: a good number for a fourth-year incumbent. She is likely the stronger contender, regardless of who will lead the opposition. Her Brothers of Italy party tops the polls. However, she suffers from incumbency fatigue and has a mixed record on the issues that matter most for voters: the economy and prices, and increasingly foreign policy. Right-wing parties are most credible on immigration and law-and-order, and are focusing their efforts there, but these issues are less salient.

The opposition lacks cohesion and a strong candidate. The broad opposition alliance will come together out of necessity. NF joining the right-wing coalition would likely prompt the only small centrist party that is still holding out to join the left (a 60% probability). However, the alliance is no less divided. It lacks a unifying vision, shared program, and leader. Likely primary elections this fall risk deepening divisions but could yet yield a surprise consensus candidate. Irrespective of the choice of leader, the opposition too may prove to be less than the sum of its parts.

The policy outlook is likely to deteriorate marginally. A center-right coalition would see a continuation of Meloni's centrist, pro-EU track, but FN would act as a considerable spoiler. On economic policy, the risk of meaningful fiscal slippage would be limited given EU commitments and bond market pressure. Prospects for economic reforms would remain minimal. Foreign policy would see the greater impact. The government will struggle to back further EU financial assistance for Ukraine or EU accession. Any meaningful increase in military spending per NATO requirements will be difficult to sustain beyond 2027.

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